

SMT Equipment

Demand Doubling Every Year

With increase in indigenous production of telecom, automotive electronics, consumer electronics and LED products, the demand for SMT machines—new and used—is expected to accelerate soon

■ UMA BANSAL

Demand for surface-mount technology (SMT) equipment is rising steadily in India. With the government's thrust on electronics hardware manufacturing, the country is fast becoming a hub for original equipment manufacturers (OEMs) and electronic manufacturing services (EMS) companies. Today, many of the global majors in EMS have footprint in India. The growing manufacturing of electronic products, in turn, is increasing the sales of SMT equipment.

In the manufacturing process, SMT equipment are used for such functions as placement, inspection, soldering, screen printing, glue dispensing and cleaning. These are classified based on the required volume of manufacturing: low to medium, medium to large, and very large.

"The market is improving for us as various OEMs have taken keen interest in SMT equipment to have the in-house facility. And soon we will see big changes," says M.K. Krishnakumar, country manager, Essemtec India.

"The growth drivers are our own requirements in telecom, automotive, lighting and consumer electronics. As far as the growth of SMT machines is concerned, leading players like Flextronics, Sollectron Centum, Jabil and Elcoteq have already contributed to



Autotronic BS683V pick-and-place machine from EMS Technologies

the SMT market in the high-volume segment. Indian EMS providers also contribute to the growth of the Indian market."

Especially, "large-scale production

setups for automotive, lighting, LED and solar products are boosting the demand," adds Prasad Gurjal, managing partner, Drive Technologies.

The demand is increasing two-fold every year, but it is still below the expected level. "The SMT equipment market has started moving forward, but it has not taken off as expected. The demand drivers like cellphones, STBs and other consumer electronics products are still dependant on China. There seems some revival though in the automotive sector," says N. Chandramohan, country head (SMT division), Juki India. "The ecosystem is the main cause of the demand

still not picking up. While there is a huge demand in consumption, components and associated industries are still lacking."

Demand mostly from telecom and automotive sectors

As mentioned earlier, telecom (2G and 3G telecom networks), automotive,

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